# Friends of the Mihai Eminescu Trust Newsletter

December 2017

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## LEIGHTON HOUSE

On 7th March, the annual celebration for the Friends of the Trust was held at Leighton House in London, former home of the Victorian artist Frederic Lord Leighton. The House, which contains a fascinating collection of paintings and sculptures by Leighton as well as textiles, pottery and other objects collected during his travels in the Middle East, provided an ideal background in which to reflect on the ongoing work of the Mihai Eminescu Trust. The Stoica family provided delicious Avinci wine from their ancient vineyards in Romania.

*Leighton House (Photo: The London Magazine - Jonathan West)*

The speakers were Jeremy Musson (architectural historian, historic buildings consultant, writer and broadcaster), David Campbell (publisher of Everyman's Library), Daniel Robbins (Senior Curator, Leighton House Museum) and Jessica Douglas-Home (Chairman of the Mihai Eminescu Trust).

"...What beguiles and intrigues me most in these Saxon villages is the almost mystical connection between old houses and the landscape, nature and agriculture; the significance of the trust's work on these houses and churches, lies in their relationship to the communities together: it lies in the importance of LIFE in these buildings, and the buildings in the LIFE of people".

*Jeremy Musson at the Leighton House celebration*

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## ALMA VII CHURCH RESTORATION OFFICIAL OPENING

*The Alma Vii church before restoration (Photo: Tessa Traeger).*

The medieval fortified church in the village of Alma Vii was reopened after 18 months of restoration focusing on the fortifications which had been under risk of collapse. Electricity has been installed, floors laid and doors and windows fitted in the towers, one of which is a guest house, the remaining three are small museums and a shop. The project was designed, implemented and funded by MET, its partner NIKU (the Norwegian Institute for Cultural Heritage Research). We also thank Richard Oldfield for his wonderful donation.

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## RICHIS

MET's restored house, No. 119 Richis - originally owned by the Mantsch family - was opened to villagers and friends this Autumn.

*The Mantsch family in 1925*

*Inside the restored house, the library, kitchen and a top floor bedroom*

We honour our architect Noemi Simo for her inspired ideas and the implementation of the restoration. Our thanks to David Mlinaric and Jane Ormsby Gore for their invaluable help in planning the house interior, as well as John Murray for his help in completing the library, and for the books generously given by Richard Eeles, Professors Roy Foster and David Wiggins, David Campbell, Hertford College, Stephen Walsh, Reni Dworkin Brendel and Victor Sebasteyen. We also thank Jojo Hull for the bookcase's gold lettering and Mark Lutyens for his help with the courtyard garden.

If you would like booking information for 119 Richis see: Experience Transylvania

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## MET and ACCOR

### Planning for the Planet Programme

On the 22nd May, the president of Romania, Klaus Werner Iohannis, came to Braşov to plant the **2 millionth** tree for us - a project that has been going for 6 years. This year 12 schools and countless volunteers participated in the programme, restoring degraded natural ecosystems and at the same time raising awareness of important environmental issues. One school orchard was established in Plăieşii de Jos.

**Varieties of species planted over the 6 years**: *Quercus robur* (Oak), *Quercus petraea* (Evergreen oak), *Fagus* (Beech), *Picea abies* (Spruce fir), *Acer pseudoplatanus* (Sycamore), *Fraxinus* (Ash), *Pinus* (Pine tree), *Abies* (Sliver fir), *Larix* (Larch fir).

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## BUTCHER'S TOWER

*The Butcher's Tower forms part of the Sighișoara citadel wall*

The necessary building permits, architectural, technical and legal plans for the restoration and conversion of the Butcher's Tower and Bastion have now been obtained. Work on the Tower and its secret walled garden will start next year.

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## A FUTURE WITHOUT RUBBISH

**CLEAR PUBLIC SPACE** is a pioneering business that addresses the problem of waste, the aim is to dramatically improve recycling rates and clear public spaces of litter. It began 12 months ago in Valea Viilor and has expanded in UNESCO-listed areas in Romania. The launch of its project 'A Future without Rubbish' took place in Cisnădie in October, attended by MET trustees and director Caroline Fernolend. EU Commissioner Helmut Maurer urged that 'the project should be adopted by all EU member states....'. Following the launch, journalists and officials were taken on a visit to a participating school to see the work in action.

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## VILLAGE PROJECTS

The MET has led in 9 village community projects in Archita, Alma Vii, Viscri, Mâlâncrav, Biertan and Richis, as well as in the town of Sighișoara. All are aimed at reinforcing Transylvania's traditional culture, conserving its natural heritage and developing the growing demand for cultural tourism. The focus is on the restoration of buildings, the provision of language courses, creative workshops, training in entrepreneurship and the presentation of handcrafted products. Individuals are encouraged to take part in developing the economy of their villages, to develop their own businesses and are given guidance in building professional careers.

For their support, we thank the Rothschild Foundation Hanadiv Europe, Europa Nostra, The Norwegian Institute for Cultural Heritage Research (NIKU), Accor, the Romanian Government's Department for Interethnic Relations, The Faro Convention Network, the ASTRA Museum, TransylvaNET, Leuphana University of Lüneburg and ICon Arts.

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## BUILDINGS RESTORATION AND UPGRADES

During the last two years we have completed restoration works on the roofs, courtyards, sewage systems, wells, barns, electric and heating systems, plumbing water tanks, windows, gates, wooden fences, interior and exterior lime wash, ceramic stoves and verandas on houses in ten of our villages (Viscri, Stejărenii, Mălâncrav, Alma Vii, Archita, Criț, Cloașterf, Florești, Biertan, Richis and in the town of Sighişoara).

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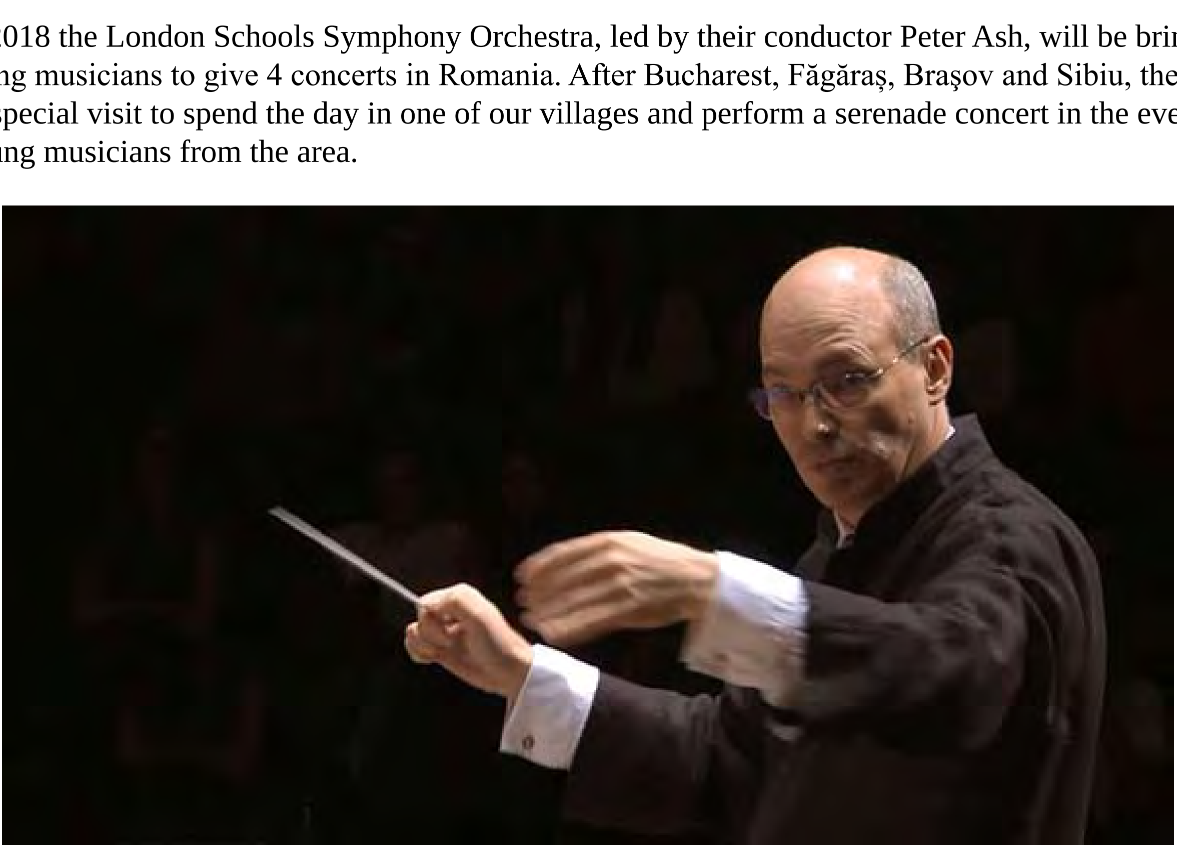
## MUSIC and the MET

The Mihai Eminescu Trust supported a festival of concerts and performances arranged by the Union of Interpretative Creation of Romanian Musicians. Several events were organised with the MET in the villages of Cloaşterf, Alma Vii and Mălâncrav.

### *Breaking News*

In July 2018 the London Schools Symphony Orchestra, led by their conductor Peter Ash, will be bringing 100 young musicians to give 4 concerts in Romania. After Bucharest, Făgăraș, Braşov and Sibiu, they will make a special visit to spend the day in one of our villages and perform a serenade concert in the evening with young musicians from the area.



*Peter Ash, Artistic Director & Conductor of the London Schools Symphony Orchestra*

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## ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The projects described above are only a selection of the highlights from projects completed during 2017.

The Horizon Foundation provided funding and sponsorship for which we are most grateful.

Partners: Horizon Foundation, Accor France, Fundatia Liviu Tudor, EEA Grants- through the NGO Fund in Romania, Grant from Switzerland through the Swiss Contribution to the enlarged European Union, AFCN - National Cultural Fund Administration, POS Mediu, Town Hall Bistrita, Consulat of the Federal Republic of Germany in Sibiu, Council of Europe.

We thank all those who joined Friends of the MET, and our thanks for all their generous donations.

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## FUNDING

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any offerings to our mailing address below. Over its first 12 years the MET benefited from the remarkable generosity of the Packard Humanities Institute. Their programme of giving came to a conclusion five years ago so, in order to continue with our restoration projects, we must look elsewhere for our funding, which makes every grant or donation all the more valuable. In 2018 our major new project will be the Alexander Franz house, in addition we'll be getting under way with another 8 important house restorations.

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**Our mailing address is:**
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